

Standard Operating Procedure

Infant and Child Abduction Prevention and Response

«Hospital Name» — Supports COP.11.f (Stop-Work)

SOP No.	[Hospital to define]	Version	1.0
Effective Date	_____	Review Frequency	Annual, or on change
Prepared By	Quality Coordinator Name: _____ Signature: _____		
Approved By	Medical Superintendent Name: _____ Signature: _____		

1. Purpose

This SOP describes how «Hospital Name» prevents infant and child abduction, and responds immediately if a child is found missing.

2. Scope

Applies to every area caring for infants and children — maternity, nursery, NICU, and paediatric ward.

3. Responsibility

Every Staff Member in the Area: watches for unusual behaviour and challenges anyone attempting to remove an infant/child without verified authorisation.

Security: responds immediately to an abduction alert and secures exits.

4. Procedure

4.1 Prevention

1. Keep CCTV coverage active over all exits from areas where infants/children are cared for, with footage retained per the hospital's defined period.
2. Educate parents at admission on hospital identification procedures — a legitimate staff member removing their infant/child will always be identifiable.
3. Be alert to unusual behaviour — a person unfamiliar with the unit, asking unusual questions, or carrying a bag near an infant is a signal to verify identity, not ignore.

4.2 Response

1. The moment a child is found missing, activate the hospital's alert code immediately — do not delay to search informally first.
2. Secure all exits and begin a systematic search per the hospital's response plan.
3. Notify the police per statutory requirement without delay.

5. Stop-Work Authority

Any staff member may stop and verify the identity of anyone attempting to remove an infant or child from the unit — this is never a disciplinary matter, even if the person turns out to be authorised.

Do not delay activating the alert code while attempting to resolve a missing-child situation informally.

6. Records

Supported by Records 7 and 8 of the COP.11 Required Records pack.

7. Related Documents

- HCO_COP_11_v2_REWRITE_DRAFT — COP.11 policy

8. Review

Reviewed annually, and immediately after any abduction attempt or drill failure.

9. References

- National Center for Missing & Exploited Children. For Healthcare Professionals: Guidelines on Prevention of and Response to Infant Abductions (10th edition).
https://www.missingkids.org/content/dam/missingkids/pdfs/ForHealthCareProfessionals_10thEdition.pdf
— a free, widely-adopted guide (the basis of the "Code Adam" response model) covering prevention and response strategies for healthcare facilities.